RYAN KNOWLEDGE NEXUS

CSS COMPETITIVE EXAMINATION STUDY SERIES

# European History

## Detailed Notes on All Topics

Introduction, Background and Key Points

27 topics with CSS 2027 likelihood tags

One full A4 page for every topic in clear passages

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# Likelihood Overview for CSS 2027

The tags on each page come from the repetition pattern in the 2020 to 2026 papers. They are estimates and not a guarantee. Very high means the theme is strongly overdue or very often repeated. High means it is a regular theme. Medium means it is a possible question or a useful base for a bigger question.

| No | Topic | Likelihood |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | The Continental System | High |
| 2 | The Congress of Vienna | Very high |
| 3 | Metternich and Conservatism | Very high |
| 4 | The French Revolution | High |
| 5 | Napoleon's Domestic Reforms | High |
| 6 | The Revolutions of 1830 and 1848 | Medium |
| 7 | The Unification of Italy | Very high |
| 8 | Bismarck and the Unification of Germany | Very high |
| 9 | Bismarck's Foreign Policy | Very high |
| 10 | The Eastern Question and the Crimean War | High |
| 11 | The Bolshevik Revolution | High |
| 12 | Causes of the First World War | High |
| 13 | The Treaty of Versailles | High |
| 14 | The Policy of Appeasement | Medium |
| 15 | The Rise of Hitler | Medium |
| 16 | Dictatorship, Fascism and Nazism | High |
| 17 | How the War of 1939 Became a World War and the Role of the USA | Medium |
| 18 | The League of Nations | Medium |
| 19 | Origins of the Cold War | High |
| 20 | European Integration | Medium |
| 21 | Britain: Industrial Revolution Without Political Revolution | Medium |
| 22 | Stalinism | Medium |
| 23 | Napoleon III and the Second Empire | Medium |
| 24 | Imperialism and the Scramble for Africa | Medium |
| 25 | The Weimar Republic | Medium |
| 26 | Alexander II and Reform in Russia | Medium |
| 27 | The Balkan Wars | Medium |

# 1. The Continental System (1806 to 1812)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**HIGH**

## INTRODUCTION

The Continental System was Napoleon's plan to defeat Britain by economic war. Through the Berlin Decree of November 1806 he closed every port under French control to British ships and goods. He hoped that lost trade and unemployment would force Britain to ask for peace. Instead the system became one of the main causes of his own fall. In simple terms it was a blockade fought with decrees instead of warships. Napoleon believed that Britain's wealth depended on selling goods to Europe, so he tried to close the whole continent to those goods. The idea was clever on paper, but it needed a strong navy to enforce it and Napoleon did not have one. The system also showed that modern wars are fought with trade, prices and shortages as well as with armies.

## BACKGROUND

Britain and France had been at war since 1793. After the British victory at Trafalgar in October 1805 the French navy could not cross the Channel, so invasion was impossible. In 1806 Napoleon crushed Prussia at Jena and Auerstedt, and after the Treaty of Tilsit in 1807 Russia joined him. For the first time he controlled almost the whole European coast and could try to shut it to British trade. Britain was already the leading industrial and trading nation, and its factories sold cloth and metal goods across Europe. Its income paid for the armies of its allies, so ruining British trade would also end the coalitions against France. Napoleon now wanted to make the blockade complete, which meant that he had to control or frighten every state along the coast, from Spain and Portugal in the west to Russia in the east.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Aims.** Napoleon wished to ruin British trade, because Britain was a nation of traders. He also wanted French industry to take over the markets of Europe.
2. **The decrees.** The Berlin Decree of 1806 declared a blockade of the British Isles. The Milan Decree of 1807 allowed the seizure of neutral ships that obeyed British rules. The Fontainebleau Decree of 1810 ordered British goods to be burned. Britain replied with Orders in Council in 1807.
3. **Smuggling and sea power.** The Royal Navy ruled the seas and Britain found new markets in Latin America. Smugglers worked from Heligoland, Malta and Portugal. French customs officers were few and often took bribes. Napoleon himself sold licences to trade, which showed the system was weak.
4. **Hardship in Europe.** Coffee, sugar and cotton became scarce and costly. Ports like Hamburg, Bordeaux and Antwerp lost trade. Ordinary Europeans began to hate French rule.
5. **The Peninsular War.** Portugal refused to obey and French troops invaded in 1807. Spain was seized in 1808. The long war that followed drained men and money and was called the Spanish ulcer.
6. **The break with Russia.** In 1810 Tsar Alexander I reopened Russian ports to neutral ships. Napoleon invaded Russia in 1812 and lost his Grand Army, which opened the road to his defeat.

**Examiner's angle.** A plan meant to ruin Britain ended by ruining Napoleon, because he ruled the land but Britain ruled the sea. **Key dates:** 1805 Trafalgar, 1806 Berlin Decree, 1807 Tilsit, 1808 Spain, 1810 Russia leaves, 1812 invasion of Russia.

# 2. The Congress of Vienna (1814 to 1815)

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**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**VERY HIGH**

## INTRODUCTION

The Congress of Vienna was the meeting of the Great Powers that rebuilt Europe after the defeat of Napoleon. Its leaders were Metternich of Austria, Castlereagh of Britain, Tsar Alexander I of Russia, Hardenberg of Prussia and Talleyrand of France. It kept the peace among the Great Powers for about forty years but ignored the new forces of nationalism and liberty. The meeting did not have one single session where all decisions were made. Most of the real bargaining took place privately among the four victorious powers, and the small states had little voice. The Final Act was signed in June 1815, nine days before Waterloo. Its effects lasted far beyond the lifetime of its makers, because it set the map and the habits of diplomacy for the next hundred years.

## BACKGROUND

After twenty years of revolution and war the rulers of Europe wanted order and security. They feared a new French attack and feared the spread of revolutionary ideas. The meeting was famous for its balls and parties, which led to the saying that the Congress does not walk, it dances. Napoleon's escape from Elba in 1815 forced the Powers to finish their work quickly after Waterloo. The wars had lasted from 1792 to 1815 and had redrawn the map many times. Napoleon had abolished the Holy Roman Empire, merged hundreds of German states and placed his relatives on many thrones. The victors now had to decide what to restore and what to keep. Their guiding fear was a new revolution in France, so they sought to build a barrier of strong states around her. Tsar Alexander I also wished to gain Poland and Prussia wished to gain Saxony, which nearly caused a quarrel among the winners.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Principles.** Legitimacy meant restoring the old ruling families. Balance of power meant that no state should dominate Europe. Compensation meant that winners were rewarded with land. A fourth aim was to contain France.
2. **France.** The Bourbon king Louis XVIII was restored. After the Hundred Days France returned to its old borders, paid an indemnity and accepted an army of occupation for some years.
3. **Buffer states.** Belgium and Holland were joined as the Kingdom of the Netherlands. Prussia received the Rhineland and part of Saxony. Piedmont was strengthened. These states were meant to block France.
4. **Other settlements.** Austria took Lombardy and Venetia. Russia received most of Poland. Sweden got Norway. Switzerland was made permanently neutral. Britain kept colonies such as the Cape, Ceylon and Malta. A German Confederation of 39 states replaced the Holy Roman Empire.
5. **Achievements.** There was no war among the Great Powers until the Crimean War of 1853. The Concert of Europe gave a habit of meeting to solve crises, a forerunner of the League and the United Nations.
6. **Failures.** Poles, Belgians, Italians and Germans were passed from ruler to ruler like property. Liberalism was ignored. These grievances caused the revolutions of 1830 and 1848.

**Examiner's angle.** Vienna was a practical success and an ideological failure. It protected peace but could not stop nationalism. **Key dates:** 1814 Congress opens, 1815 Waterloo and final settlement, 1830 Belgium revolts, 1848 revolutions.

# 3. Metternich and Conservatism (1809 to 1848)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**VERY HIGH**

## INTRODUCTION

Klemens von Metternich was Foreign Minister of Austria from 1809 and Chancellor from 1821 until 1848. He believed that liberty and nationalism were dangerous diseases that would destroy order. His whole career was spent in defending the old system, so he is called the symbol of restoration and reaction. He was born in the Rhineland in 1773, was educated in the ideas of the old order and was a great diplomat who spoke elegantly in French. Historians speak of the Age of Metternich for the years between 1815 and 1848 because his influence on European politics was so strong. He was neither stupid nor cruel, but his idea of order left no room for the hopes of ordinary people.

## BACKGROUND

Austria was a multinational empire of Germans, Magyars, Czechs, Italians, Poles and Slavs. A nationalist movement in any one group could break the empire apart. After the French Revolution and the Napoleonic wars, Metternich saw himself as the doctor of Europe and set out to prevent a new revolution. At Vienna in 1815 he led the Powers toward a settlement that favoured order and Austrian influence. He became Foreign Minister in 1809 when Austria had just been beaten by Napoleon, and he first made peace by arranging the marriage of Napoleon to the Austrian princess Marie Louise in 1810. Later he turned against Napoleon and joined the final coalition. His success at Vienna in 1815 made Austria again a leading power. He believed that Austria's position at the centre of Europe made her the natural guardian of stability, so that any revolt in Italy or Germany was also a danger to Austria.

## KEY POINTS

1. **The Congress System.** Meetings at Aix la Chapelle in 1818, Troppau in 1820, Laibach in 1821 and Verona in 1822 aimed to crush revolutions. The Troppau Protocol said the Powers could use force against any state where revolution threatened peace.
2. **Intervention in Italy.** Austrian troops put down the revolts in Naples and Piedmont in 1820 and 1821. Austria also kept control of Lombardy and Venetia.
3. **Carlsbad Decrees, 1819.** After a student murdered the writer Kotzebue, Metternich forced the German states to accept censorship, police control of universities and a ban on student societies.
4. **The police state.** In Austria he built a large network of spies and censors. Books were banned and travel was watched. Fear and silence became the method of rule.
5. **Limits.** Britain refused to join his interventions. Greece won independence against his wishes. The July Revolution in France in 1830 and the Belgian revolt showed that the system was cracking.
6. **Fall.** He ignored the rise of the middle class and the workers. In March 1848 revolution reached Vienna, and Metternich resigned and fled to England.

**Examiner's angle.** Metternich gave Europe a long peace but tried to stop history instead of guiding it. A saying attributed to him is that when France sneezes, Europe catches cold. **Key dates:** 1815 Vienna, 1819 Carlsbad Decrees, 1820 Troppau Protocol, 1830 July Revolution, 1848 fall.

# 4. The French Revolution (1789 to 1799)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**HIGH**

## INTRODUCTION

The French Revolution began in 1789 and changed Europe for ever. It grew out of an unfair social system, a bankrupt state and the new ideas of the Enlightenment. Once it began, fear of enemies at home and abroad pushed it from reform to terror. It ended feudal privilege and spread the ideas of liberty, equality and nation across the continent. Historians often divide it into stages: a moderate stage up to 1792, a radical stage in 1793 and 1794, and a conservative stage under the Directory. Its slogan of liberty, equality and fraternity became the motto of later reformers across the world. For CSS answers it is important to show both the causes and the results, and to explain why the Revolution moved from hope to terror.

## BACKGROUND

Before 1789 France was an absolute monarchy under Louis XVI. Society was divided into three Estates. The clergy and nobility were a small group who owned much land and paid few taxes. The Third Estate, the peasants, workers and middle class, paid almost all the taxes. Wars, including help given to the American Revolution, had left the crown deeply in debt, and the bad harvest of 1788 made bread dear. The king's ministers had tried to solve the money problem by taxing the nobles, but the nobles used their law courts, the parlements, to block reform. In 1787 the Assembly of Notables also refused to agree. By 1788 nearly half of the state's spending went on debt payments. When the harvest failed that year, bread prices rose so high that a worker had to spend most of his wages on bread. This mixture of financial crisis, hunger and a stubborn aristocracy led the king to call the Estates General in 1789.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Causes.** Social injustice, debt, weak leadership and failed reforms by ministers such as Turgot, Necker and Calonne made change certain. The Estates General met in May 1789, for the first time since 1614.
2. **Enlightenment ideas.** Voltaire attacked the Church and asked for tolerance. Montesquieu argued for separation of powers. Rousseau taught that power belongs to the people. The Declaration of the Rights of Man in August 1789 turned these ideas into law.
3. **1789.** The Third Estate formed the National Assembly and took the Tennis Court Oath. The Bastille fell on 14 July. The Great Fear spread through the villages and feudal privileges were abolished.
4. **Radicalisation.** The king's flight to Varennes in 1791 destroyed trust. War with Austria and Prussia in 1792 brought fear of invasion and traitors. The monarchy fell and Louis XVI was executed in January 1793.
5. **The Terror.** The Committee of Public Safety under Robespierre ruled by terror in 1793 and 1794 and more than sixteen thousand people were guillotined. Robespierre fell in July 1794 and the Directory followed.
6. **Results.** Feudalism ended and citizens became equal before the law. Nationalism and modern politics were born. The weak Directory opened the way for Napoleon in 1799.

**Examiner's angle.** Ideas lit the fire and fear fed it. Deep causes made change certain, but a stronger king and early compromise might have prevented the violence. **Key dates:** 1789 Bastille, 1791 Varennes, 1792 war, 1793 king executed, 1794 Robespierre falls, 1799 Napoleon.

# 5. Napoleon's Domestic Reforms (1799 to 1815)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**HIGH**

## INTRODUCTION

Napoleon Bonaparte seized power in 1799, became First Consul for life in 1802 and Emperor in 1804. His wars ended in defeat at Waterloo, but many of his reforms inside France survived him and spread across Europe. This is why his civil work is called granite. Napoleon said that he had ended the Revolution by making its best ideas permanent. This is only partly true. He kept equality, property rights and careers open to talent, but he took away the freedom of the press and of political debate. His plebiscites gave him a popular look but real power rested in his own hands. For examiners the key skill is to weigh both sides of his rule.

## BACKGROUND

By 1799 France was exhausted by ten years of revolution and the weak Directory had lost the trust of the people. Napoleon, a successful general, took power by the coup of Brumaire and promised order, stability and the safety of the gains of the Revolution. He used plebiscites to give his rule a popular look while holding real power himself. The coup of 18 Brumaire in November 1799 replaced the Directory with three Consuls, and Napoleon as First Consul held the real power under the new constitution. He knew that a government needed money, order and loyal officials, so he began with administration and finance. He also allowed many emigres who had fled during the Revolution to return, which healed old wounds and strengthened the state. He also sought the loyalty of the French people through public ceremonies and the symbols of power. His coronation in Notre Dame in December 1804 was a sign of his new status, and he crowned himself in the presence of the Pope.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Government.** He created prefects in every department who were appointed from Paris. This gave France an orderly and centralised administration. Careers were open to talent.
2. **Finance.** He founded the Bank of France in 1800, organised fair tax collection and gave France a stable currency, the franc.
3. **The Concordat of 1801.** Napoleon made peace with Pope Pius VII. Catholicism was recognised as the religion of most French people and the sale of Church land stayed in force. Religious conflict ended.
4. **The Civil Code of 1804.** His greatest work guaranteed equality before the law, protection of property, religious freedom and the end of feudal privilege. Its weakness was that women and children were placed under the father's power.
5. **Education and honour.** Lycees were opened in 1802 and the Imperial University in 1808. The Legion of Honour of 1802 rewarded service to the state.
6. **The dark side.** Newspapers were censored, the secret police under Fouche watched the people, and slavery was restored in the colonies in 1802. He gave order but took away political freedom.

**Examiner's angle.** Napoleon lost his empire but left modern administration, law, banking and education. He kept the equality of the Revolution and took away its liberty. **Key dates:** 1799 Brumaire, 1800 Bank of France, 1801 Concordat, 1802 Consul for life, 1804 Civil Code and Empire, 1815 Waterloo.

# 6. The Revolutions of 1830 and 1848 (1830 to 1849)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**MEDIUM**

## INTRODUCTION

After 1815 the Vienna system kept Europe under conservative rule. Two waves of revolution, in 1830 and 1848, tried to break it. In the short term most of them failed. In the long term they changed the direction of European history. The two waves are often studied together because they had the same causes and the same enemies. The first wave was limited to western Europe and ended in partial success. The second wave, called the Springtime of Peoples, spread from Paris to nearly every capital in central Europe within weeks. Examiners usually ask whether the revolutions failed or succeeded, so a balanced judgment is needed.

## BACKGROUND

The Congress of Vienna had restored kings and ignored nationalism and liberalism. The middle class wanted constitutions and a share of power. Workers suffered from low wages and unemployment in the new factory towns. Nationalists in Italy, Germany, Poland and Hungary wanted freedom and unity. These pressures grew stronger during the long peace. The Industrial Revolution was creating a new middle class of factory owners and merchants who paid taxes but had no vote, and a new working class that lived in crowded towns. The Vienna settlement had set up governments that ignored both. Writers and students spread the ideas of national freedom and constitutions through newspapers and societies despite censorship. A series of bad harvests between 1845 and 1847 and a financial crisis in 1846 and 1847 turned this discontent into open anger.

## KEY POINTS

1. **1830 in France.** Charles X issued the July Ordinances to dissolve the Chamber and censor the press. Paris rose in the three glorious days of 27 to 29 July. Charles fled and Louis Philippe became the citizen king.
2. **1830 elsewhere.** Belgium revolted and won independence, recognised in 1831. Poland rose against Russia and was crushed. Austrian troops put down revolts in central Italy.
3. **Causes of 1848.** Hunger after the potato blight and bad harvests, unemployment, middle class anger, nationalism and the spread of socialist ideas such as the Communist Manifesto.
4. **The events of 1848.** Revolution in Paris in February created the Second Republic. In March it reached Vienna and Berlin, and Metternich fell. Hungary under Kossuth demanded self rule. Italy saw risings in Milan and Venice. The Frankfurt Parliament met to plan German unity.
5. **Why 1848 failed.** Liberals and radicals quarrelled. The middle class feared the workers. The nationalities fought each other. The armies stayed loyal. Russia helped Austria crush Hungary in 1849 and the Prussian king refused the crown offered by Frankfurt.
6. **Long term results.** Serfdom ended in the Austrian Empire. Prussia received a constitution. Piedmont kept its liberal constitution. Cavour and Bismarck learned that unity needs power and diplomacy, not speeches.

**Examiner's angle.** A. J. P. Taylor called 1848 a turning point at which history failed to turn. The better view is a short term failure and a long term success. **Key dates:** 1830 July Revolution and Belgium, 1848 revolutions, 1849 Hungary crushed and Frankfurt fails.

# 7. The Unification of Italy (1815 to 1870)

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**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**VERY HIGH**

## INTRODUCTION

The unification of Italy, called the Risorgimento, was the process by which the divided states of the Italian peninsula became one kingdom between 1859 and 1870. It was led by Piedmont under Prime Minister Cavour and King Victor Emmanuel II, with the help of Mazzini's ideas, Garibaldi's volunteers and the wars of the Great Powers. Together with German unification it was one of the two great acts of nation building in nineteenth century Europe. Historians debate whether unity was the work of far sighted planning or of lucky chances. The unification was completed in stages and not all Italians were equally pleased, because the poor south felt that it had been conquered by Piedmont. This question of calculation and improvisation is a favourite theme in CSS papers.

## BACKGROUND

In 1815 the Congress of Vienna left Italy cut into seven states. Austria ruled Lombardy and Venetia directly and controlled the small duchies. The Pope ruled the Papal States and a Bourbon king ruled the Two Sicilies. Only Piedmont Sardinia had an Italian ruling family. Napoleon had earlier shown Italians the benefits of one law and one government, and nationalism grew among the middle class. Secret societies such as the Carbonari rose in 1820 and 1831, but Austrian troops crushed them. Metternich dismissed Italy as only a geographical expression. Piedmont Sardinia was the one state where the king, the army and the economy were strong, and its position at the foot of the Alps made it the natural leader. Italians also lived under very different laws, taxes and currencies, which made daily life and trade difficult and gave practical reasons for unity as well as patriotic ones.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Mazzini and Young Italy (1831).** Mazzini dreamed of a free republic and believed in moral force. His risings failed because he had no army, but his writings gave Italians a clear idea and strong enthusiasm.
2. **Piedmont takes the lead (1848 and 1849).** King Charles Albert fought Austria and lost at Custoza and Novara. He gave up the throne to Victor Emmanuel II, who kept the liberal constitution. This made Piedmont the hope of Italian patriots.
3. **Cavour's diplomacy.** As Prime Minister from 1852 he modernised Piedmont's economy and army. He sent troops to the Crimean War so that Piedmont could raise the Italian question at the Paris Congress of 1856. In 1858 the Pact of Plombieres promised French help against Austria in return for Nice and Savoy.
4. **The war of 1859.** French and Piedmontese armies won at Magenta and Solferino. Napoleon III then made peace at Villafranca and Piedmont received only Lombardy. In 1860 Tuscany, Parma, Modena and Romagna voted by plebiscite to join Piedmont.
5. **Garibaldi and the Thousand (1860).** Garibaldi and his Red Shirts conquered Sicily and Naples. Cavour feared an attack on Rome, so he sent the Piedmontese army through the Papal States. At Teano Garibaldi handed the south to Victor Emmanuel, and the Kingdom of Italy was proclaimed in March 1861.
6. **Completion (1866 and 1870).** Venetia came in 1866 through the alliance with Prussia against Austria. Rome was taken in 1870 when French troops left to fight Prussia. Trentino and Trieste stayed under Austria and were called unredeemed Italy.

**Examiner's angle.** Cavour planned the diplomacy, but Garibaldi's success and the wars of other powers decided the result. The best answer says that unity came through a mixture of calculation, improvisation and luck. **Key dates:** 1831 Young Italy, 1858 Plombieres, 1860 the Thousand, 1861 Kingdom of Italy, 1866 Venetia, 1870 Rome.

# 8. Bismarck and the Unification of Germany (1862 to 1871)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**VERY HIGH**

## INTRODUCTION

Otto von Bismarck became Prime Minister of Prussia in 1862 and by 1871 had created the German Empire. He did it through three short wars and clever diplomacy. He believed in Realpolitik, which means politics of power and practical interest. In his own words the great questions of the day would be decided not by speeches but by iron and blood. He was born in 1815 into the Junker landowning class, studied law and was a fierce defender of the Prussian king. He disliked liberals and democrats, yet he used the force of nationalism to build a new state. This mix of conservative aims and modern methods makes him one of the most interesting statesmen in European history and a favourite of examiners.

## BACKGROUND

After 1815 Germany was a loose Confederation of 39 states led by Austria. Prussia grew strong through its army and through the Zollverein of 1834, a customs union that tied German economies together and left Austria out. The failure of the Frankfurt Parliament in 1848 showed that unity by speeches would not work. In 1862 King William I called Bismarck to win a quarrel with Parliament over the army budget. Prussia and Austria were rivals for leadership of the German states. Austria had the old prestige of the Holy Roman Empire, but Prussia had a growing economy in the Ruhr and Saar coalfields, a good railway system and a disciplined army. The question was whether Germany would be united under Austria, including its many non German peoples, or under Prussia in a smaller Germany without Austria. Bismarck chose the second plan, known as the small German solution.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Army and nation.** Bismarck ruled without a legal budget and made the Prussian army stronger under Roon and Moltke. Success abroad would later win him the support of the nation.
2. **War with Denmark, 1864.** Prussia and Austria together took Schleswig and Holstein. Their joint rule of the two duchies created a quarrel that Bismarck used against Austria.
3. **War with Austria, 1866.** Bismarck first secured Russian friendship, French neutrality and an alliance with Italy. Prussia crushed Austria at Sadowa in seven weeks. Austria was excluded from German affairs and the North German Confederation was formed under Prussia. He gave a mild peace to keep Austria as a future friend.
4. **War with France, 1870 to 1871.** A Hohenzollern prince was proposed for Spain. Bismarck edited the Ems Telegram so that it sounded insulting to both sides and France declared war. Napoleon III was captured at Sedan in September 1870.
5. **The Empire.** The German Empire was proclaimed in the Hall of Mirrors at Versailles on 18 January 1871. France lost Alsace and Lorraine and paid five billion francs.
6. **Impact on Europe.** Germany replaced France as the leading land power. France became an enemy for life because of Alsace and Lorraine. Many historians trace the roots of the First World War to this settlement.

**Examiner's angle.** Bismarck was the architect of unity but he also used favourable conditions, the Prussian army, industrial growth and the mistakes of Napoleon III. **Key dates:** 1834 Zollverein, 1862 Bismarck in power, 1864 Denmark, 1866 Sadowa, 1870 Sedan, 1871 Empire.

# 9. Bismarck's Foreign Policy (1871 to 1890)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**VERY HIGH**

## INTRODUCTION

After 1871 Bismarck believed that Germany was satisfied and wanted only peace. His main fears were French revenge for Alsace and Lorraine and a war on two fronts. His system was a web of alliances meant to isolate France and keep every other power friendly with Germany. His diplomacy is often described as a system, but he himself saw it as a series of arrangements to meet each danger as it came. The central idea was that Germany should be the hub of a wheel with friendly states around it. The strength of the plan was its flexibility and the weakness was that it needed a master of intrigue to manage it.

## BACKGROUND

Germany had been created by war and was now the strongest power on the continent. France was humiliated and wanted revenge. The Balkans were unstable because the Ottoman Empire was weak, and Austria and Russia were rivals there. Bismarck knew that a quarrel in the Balkans could break his plans. He called his greatest fear the nightmare of coalitions against Germany. The new Germany had no natural frontier in east or west and faced France, Russia and Austria. Britain had a navy and wealth, and Bismarck wished to avoid any quarrel with her. The war scare of 1875, when German newspapers talked of a new attack on France, showed him that Britain and Russia would not allow Germany to crush France again, so he turned to peaceful alliances. Bismarck also used the press and personal contacts to influence other governments. He met foreign ministers privately, sent warnings through newspapers and sometimes created war scares to bring other states into line. His methods were often unscrupulous, but he always kept the final aim of peace in mind.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Aims.** Isolate France. Keep Russia and Austria friendly with Germany and with each other. Avoid colonial quarrels with Britain.
2. **League of the Three Emperors, 1873.** Germany, Austria and Russia agreed to cooperate against revolution. It broke down in 1878 because of Austrian and Russian rivalry in the Balkans.
3. **Congress of Berlin, 1878.** After the Russo Turkish War Russia gained much at San Stefano. Bismarck acted as honest broker at Berlin and reduced Russian gains. Russia felt betrayed.
4. **The alliances.** The Dual Alliance with Austria in 1879. The Triple Alliance with Austria and Italy in 1882. The secret Reinsurance Treaty with Russia in 1887, by which each promised neutrality if the other fought a third power.
5. **Colonies.** He allowed colonies in Africa and the Pacific in 1884 and 1885 and held the Berlin Conference, but he did not make colonies his main aim.
6. **After Bismarck.** In 1890 Kaiser William II dismissed Bismarck and let the Reinsurance Treaty lapse. France and Russia allied in 1894 and Germany faced two enemies.

**Examiner's angle.** Bismarck kept the peace for nearly twenty years but built a system that depended on one man. After 1890 the alliances hardened into rival blocs, which made war in 1914 more likely. **Key dates:** 1873 Three Emperors, 1878 Berlin, 1879 Dual Alliance, 1882 Triple Alliance, 1887 Reinsurance Treaty, 1890 dismissal, 1894 France and Russia.

# 10. The Eastern Question and the Crimean War (1821 to 1914)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**HIGH**

## INTRODUCTION

The Eastern Question means the problem of what would happen to the lands of the declining Ottoman Empire, which Tsar Nicholas I called the sick man of Europe. Russia, Austria, Britain and France each wanted influence or safety in the region. The question troubled Europe from about 1800 to 1914 and finally helped to cause the First World War. Different powers looked at the question in different ways. For Russia it was a matter of religion and trade routes, for Britain it was the safety of the route to India, for Austria it was the survival of its empire, and for France it was prestige and influence in the Mediterranean. This clash of interests is why the question lasted so long and ended in a world war.

## BACKGROUND

The Ottoman Empire was weak and its Christian subjects in the Balkans began to demand freedom. Russia wanted access to warm waters through the Straits and claimed to protect Orthodox Christians. Britain feared Russia near the Mediterranean and India. Austria feared Slav nationalism inside its own empire. Each power wanted a share of the empire's lands but none wanted another power to take too much. The Ottoman Empire had once been a great power that reached the gates of Vienna in 1683. By the nineteenth century it was losing land and money and its armies lagged behind Europe's. Its Christian subjects in the Balkans, including Serbs, Greeks, Bulgarians and Romanians, were inspired by nationalism. The Sultan could not satisfy them without losing his empire and could not suppress them without bringing in foreign powers, so the empire became a stage for great power rivalry.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Early stages.** The Greek War of Independence began in 1821 and won freedom after the Battle of Navarino in 1827 and the Treaty of Adrianople in 1829. The Straits Convention of 1841 closed the Straits to warships in peacetime.
2. **Causes of the Crimean War.** France and Russia quarrelled over the Holy Places in Palestine. Nicholas demanded protection of all Orthodox Christians in the Ottoman Empire. When the Sultan refused, Russia occupied the Danubian principalities in 1853. Britain and France joined the Turks in 1854.
3. **The war.** The long siege of Sevastopol ended in September 1855. Disease killed more men than bullets. Florence Nightingale became famous for her nursing work.
4. **Treaty of Paris, 1856.** The Black Sea was neutralised, the Danube was opened to all and the Ottoman Empire was guaranteed. Russia was humbled and began reforms. Austria angered Russia by staying neutral and the old friendship between them broke.
5. **Later crises.** Revolts in Bosnia and Bulgaria led to the Russo Turkish War and the Congress of Berlin in 1878, which recognised the independence of Serbia, Montenegro and Romania.
6. **The new phase, 1908 to 1914.** The Young Turk revolution of 1908 weakened the Sultan. Austria annexed Bosnia in 1908. The Balkan Wars of 1912 and 1913 drove the Ottomans almost out of Europe. Serbia grew strong and Austria feared it. This led to Sarajevo in 1914.

**Examiner's angle.** The Eastern Question was about the weakness of one empire and the greed of many. It caused the Crimean War, redrew the Balkans and finally ignited the world war. **Key dates:** 1829 Adrianople, 1853 to 1856 Crimean War, 1878 Berlin, 1908 Bosnia annexed, 1912 to 1913 Balkan Wars, 1914 Sarajevo.

# 11. The Bolshevik Revolution (1917)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**HIGH**

## INTRODUCTION

Russia in 1917 passed through two revolutions in one year. In February the Tsar was overthrown and in October the Bolsheviks under Lenin seized power. The result was the first communist state in history. The dates in this note follow the old Russian calendar, which was thirteen days behind the western calendar. The revolution was not only a Russian event. It was the start of a new kind of state based on the rule of a single party and on the ideas of Karl Marx as understood by Lenin. For CSS answers it is helpful to separate the causes of the fall of the Tsar from the causes of the Bolshevik victory, since they are different questions.

## BACKGROUND

Tsar Nicholas II ruled as an absolute monarch over a backward empire. Peasants wanted land and workers lived in poor conditions. The revolution of 1905 after Bloody Sunday forced the October Manifesto and an elected Duma, but the Tsar took back most of his promises. Defeats in the First World War, hunger and the influence of Rasputin ruined the Tsar's name. Russia was a huge country with a small industrial working class concentrated in cities like Petrograd and Moscow, where factory conditions were harsh. About eighty percent of the people were peasants who wanted the nobles' land. Political parties were illegal until 1905. Nicholas II believed in autocracy and refused to share power. The war then made everything worse, since the army was badly supplied and the railways broke down, so that food did not reach the cities.

## KEY POINTS

1. **The February Revolution.** In March 1917 by the western calendar, strikes and bread riots began in Petrograd. Soldiers refused to fire on the crowd and joined it. The Tsar abdicated and a Provisional Government was formed.
2. **Dual power.** The Petrograd Soviet of workers and soldiers shared real power with the Provisional Government. The Government decided to continue the war and delayed land reform. Kerensky's July offensive failed and the people lost patience.
3. **Lenin and the Bolsheviks.** Lenin returned in April and issued the April Theses with the slogans of Peace, Land and Bread and All Power to the Soviets. The Bolsheviks were small, disciplined and clear in their aims. Trotsky organised the Military Revolutionary Committee.
4. **The October Revolution.** On 25 October by the old calendar the Bolsheviks seized the Winter Palace with very little fighting. They announced the Decree on Peace and the Decree on Land at once.
5. **Effects inside Russia.** The Constituent Assembly was dissolved in January 1918. Russia made the Treaty of Brest Litovsk with Germany in March 1918. A cruel civil war between Reds and Whites followed until 1921, and the Cheka used terror. The USSR was formed in 1922.
6. **Effects on the world.** Communism became a world force and the Comintern was founded in 1919. Fear of communism helped fascism in Italy and Germany. The Revolution is one of the roots of the Cold War.

**Examiner's angle.** The Bolsheviks won because the old order was weak, the war was a disaster and Lenin offered simple promises with strong organisation. **Key dates:** 1905 first revolution, 1917 February and October, 1918 Brest Litovsk, 1918 to 1921 civil war, 1922 USSR.

# 12. Causes of the First World War (1914 to 1918)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**HIGH**

## INTRODUCTION

The First World War began in August 1914 and lasted until November 1918. Historians speak of long term causes that made Europe a powder barrel and a short term spark at Sarajevo. The long causes are easy to recall by the letters M A I N, which stand for Militarism, Alliances, Imperialism and Nationalism. Historians have argued for a century about who was to blame. The war was not caused by one single factor and no single leader wanted a war as large as the one that came. Each cause made the next one more dangerous, so the best answer shows how they joined together in the summer of 1914.

## BACKGROUND

After 1871 Europe enjoyed peace between the Great Powers, but tension grew. Bismarck's alliances hardened into two camps after 1890. Germany challenged British naval power and trade. France wanted revenge for Alsace and Lorraine. Russia supported Serbia and the Slavs. The weak Ottoman and Austrian empires were under pressure in the Balkans. Europe had been at peace among the Great Powers since 1871, yet the period was one of rapid change. Germany had become the strongest industrial power on the continent and wanted a place in the sun, meaning colonies and a great navy. Britain was alarmed by the German fleet and ended her isolation by joining France and Russia in friendly understandings. Meanwhile the Austrian Empire was weakening under national pressure and its leaders thought that a war against Serbia could save it.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Alliances.** The Triple Alliance joined Germany, Austria and Italy. The Triple Entente joined Britain, France and Russia. A quarrel between two states could drag in all the others.
2. **Militarism.** Britain and Germany raced to build Dreadnought battleships. Germany's Schlieffen Plan demanded a quick attack on France through Belgium, so mobilisation became a path to war.
3. **Imperialism and nationalism.** Rivalry over colonies caused the Moroccan crises of 1905 and 1911. Pan Slavism encouraged Serbia to dream of uniting the Slavs, while Austria feared for its empire.
4. **Balkan tension.** Austria annexed Bosnia in 1908 and the Balkan Wars of 1912 and 1913 made Serbia stronger and Austria more afraid.
5. **The spark.** On 28 June 1914 Archduke Franz Ferdinand was shot at Sarajevo by Gavrilo Princip. Germany gave Austria a blank cheque on 5 July. Austria sent an ultimatum to Serbia on 23 July and declared war on 28 July.
6. **The chain reaction.** Russia mobilised. Germany declared war on Russia on 1 August and on France on 3 August and invaded Belgium. Britain declared war on 4 August to protect Belgium.

**Examiner's angle.** The Treaty of Versailles blamed Germany alone. A balanced view says Germany and Austria bore the greater responsibility for risking war, but the system of alliances and military plans made war likely. **Key dates:** 1905 and 1911 Moroccan crises, 1908 Bosnia, 28 June 1914 Sarajevo, 28 July war on Serbia, 4 August Britain joins.

# 13. The Treaty of Versailles (1919)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**HIGH**

## INTRODUCTION

The Treaty of Versailles was signed on 28 June 1919 and was imposed on Germany by the victors. Marshal Foch is said to have remarked that it was not peace but a ceasefire for twenty years. History proved him right, because the Second World War began twenty years and two months later. It was the main treaty among several, since separate treaties were signed with Austria at Saint Germain, Hungary at Trianon, Bulgaria at Neuilly and the Ottoman Empire at Sevres. Together they redrew the map of Europe and created new states such as Poland, Czechoslovakia and Yugoslavia. Germany's treaty was the most famous because it affected the most powerful loser.

## BACKGROUND

Germany asked for an armistice in November 1918 and expected a peace based on President Wilson's Fourteen Points. At the Paris Peace Conference the Big Three disagreed. Wilson wanted a just peace, Clemenceau of France wanted security and revenge, and Lloyd George of Britain wanted a middle path. Germany was not allowed to take part in the talks and had to sign what it was given. The conference opened in January 1919 at Paris. Russia was not invited and the defeated powers were kept out. France had been invaded twice in fifty years and had lost over one million soldiers, so Clemenceau demanded safety through a weak Germany. Wilson wished to create a League of Nations and base the peace on the right of nations to govern themselves. Lloyd George had promised the British public that Germany would pay, but he also feared that too harsh a peace would drive Germany to communism.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Land.** Alsace and Lorraine returned to France. The Saar was placed under the League for fifteen years. Poland received a corridor to the sea and Danzig became a free city. Germany lost all colonies as mandates.
2. **Army.** The army was limited to 100,000 men. No air force, no tanks and no submarines were allowed. The Rhineland was demilitarised. Union with Austria was forbidden.
3. **Guilt and money.** Article 231, the war guilt clause, made Germany accept responsibility. Reparations were later fixed in 1921 at 132 billion gold marks.
4. **German reaction.** Germans called it a diktat and believed the army had been betrayed by politicians, the stab in the back myth. The Weimar Republic that signed it was hated by many.
5. **Weaknesses.** It was too harsh to be accepted and too weak to keep Germany down. The United States Senate refused to ratify it in 1920, so America withdrew and Britain and France were left to enforce it alone.
6. **Result.** Hitler promised to destroy the treaty. He reoccupied the Rhineland in 1936, united with Austria in 1938 and took the Sudetenland in 1938 without serious resistance.

**Examiner's angle.** Versailles was neither generous enough to win Germany's friendship nor strong enough to keep Germany powerless. Use the word T A R G E T: Territory, Army, Reparations, Guilt, Excluded, Troops banned from the Rhineland. **Key dates:** 1918 armistice, 28 June 1919 treaty, 1920 US Senate refuses, 1921 reparations fixed, 1936 Rhineland, 1938 Anschluss.

# 14. The Policy of Appeasement (1933 to 1939)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**MEDIUM**

## INTRODUCTION

Appeasement was the policy followed mainly by Britain under Neville Chamberlain and by France in the 1930s. It tried to avoid war by giving way to the demands of Hitler and Mussolini. Churchill used the words total and unmitigated defeat in the House of Commons in October 1938 after the Munich Agreement. The word now has a bad meaning, but at the time it meant making peace by settling grievances. Many serious people supported it, including most of the British press and public. It is important to answer fairly by showing why leaders chose it, and then to judge whether it was wise.

## BACKGROUND

By the 1930s Hitler had left the League of Nations, was rebuilding the army and openly attacked the Treaty of Versailles. Britain and France were weakened by the Great Depression and horrified by the memory of 1914 to 1918. Their leaders believed that some German demands were fair and that war could be avoided by talk. Hitler came to power in 1933 and quickly showed his aims by leaving the Disarmament Conference and the League. In 1935 he announced conscription and an air force. Mussolini attacked Abyssinia in the same year. Britain's government under Baldwin and then Chamberlain, from 1937, was trying to rearm slowly while hoping that talks would calm Europe. France depended on Britain and would not act alone. Public opinion in Britain was an important force. After the horrors of the trenches many families wanted peace at almost any price, and politicians who talked of war could lose elections.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Fear of another war.** Millions had died in the First World War. Public opinion was pacifist, shown in the Peace Ballot of 1934 and 1935.
2. **Versailles and economy.** Many Britons felt that Versailles had been too harsh. The Depression made governments focus on jobs and not on weapons.
3. **Weakness and fear.** Britain's forces were not ready and the chiefs of staff warned against war with Germany, Italy and Japan together. Many conservatives feared communism more than Nazism.
4. **Lack of allies.** The United States was isolationist and the Dominions did not want war. France was divided and the League had failed in Manchuria and Abyssinia.
5. **The steps.** The Rhineland was reoccupied in 1936. Austria was united with Germany in March 1938. At Munich in September 1938 the Sudetenland was given to Germany without Czechoslovakia in the room. In March 1939 Hitler took the rest of Czechoslovakia and Britain then guaranteed Poland.
6. **Judgment.** Critics say it encouraged Hitler and lost Czech weapons. Defenders say it gave time to build Spitfires and radar and united British opinion in 1939.

**Examiner's angle.** Appeasement came from understandable fears but failed because Hitler's aims were unlimited. The lesson is that dictators grow bolder when they are not resisted early. Remember P E A C E: Pacifism, Economy, Army weak, Communism feared, Excuse of Versailles. **Key dates:** 1935 naval agreement, 1936 Rhineland, 1938 Anschluss and Munich, 1939 Prague, 1 September 1939 Poland.

# 15. The Rise of Hitler (1919 to 1933)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**MEDIUM**

## INTRODUCTION

Hitler became Chancellor of Germany on 30 January 1933. Some historians argue that French harshness after 1919 and British softness in the 1930s made his rise possible. This note takes the stance that Allied policy helped Hitler to survive and expand, but the main causes of his rise were inside Germany. To answer this question well one should separate the rise to power in 1933 from the growth of German strength afterward. The first was mainly a German story while the second depended on the weakness of Britain and France. This distinction is the secret of a strong CSS answer.

## BACKGROUND

Germany lost the war in 1918 and the Weimar Republic was born in defeat. It signed Versailles, suffered a Ruhr occupation and hyperinflation in 1923, and then recovered between 1924 and 1929 with American loans under the Dawes Plan. Hitler tried a failed Munich Putsch in 1923 and then built the Nazi party through elections. After the Munich Putsch Hitler served a short prison term in 1924, wrote Mein Kampf, and decided to win power by votes and not by force. The Nazi party grew slowly in the calm years but exploded in size during the Depression, when voters looked for a party that blamed the Republic, Versailles, communists and Jews for their misery. The party also had a private army, the SA, which gave it a street presence. The role of Germany's elites should also be remembered. Industrialists, landowners and army officers feared the left and thought that Hitler could be used to defeat communism and to restore German power. The Nazi party also won women and young voters by promising a place for everyone in the new Germany. These facts show that his support was broad and came from many sections of society.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Where the claim is true.** France pushed for harsh terms and occupied the Ruhr in 1923, which created hatred of the Republic. Britain signed a naval agreement in 1935 and did not resist Hitler in 1936 and 1938.
2. **Timing.** Hitler became Chancellor in January 1933. Most acts of appeasement came after 1935. So appeasement could not have put him in power.
3. **The Depression.** The Nazis won only 2.6 percent of votes in 1928. After the Wall Street Crash of 1929 six million Germans were jobless and the Nazi vote rose to 37 percent in July 1932.
4. **Weimar's weakness.** The system had many small parties. Article 48 let the President rule by decree. Many army officers, judges and nobles never accepted democracy.
5. **Nazi appeal.** Hitler promised work, bread and the end of Versailles. Goebbels used radio, posters and rallies. Conservatives like Papen believed they could control him and President Hindenburg appointed him.
6. **After power.** The Reichstag Fire of February 1933 and the Enabling Act of March 1933 gave him dictatorial power.

**Examiner's angle.** The claim is partly true but mostly exaggerated. Use the three step argument: timing, the Depression and Weimar's weakness. Allied policy explains his expansion, not his rise. **Key dates:** 1923 Ruhr and Putsch, 1929 Crash, 1932 Nazis at 37 percent, 30 January 1933 Chancellor, March 1933 Enabling Act.

# 16. Dictatorship, Fascism and Nazism (1917 to 1945)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**HIGH**

## INTRODUCTION

By 1939 most European states had dictatorships. Italy fell to Mussolini in 1922 and Germany to Hitler in 1933. Hungary, Spain, Portugal, Poland, Yugoslavia and Greece followed. Fascism and Nazism were close relatives but Nazism was more radical because of its racial theory and its total control. The word totalitarian is often used for Hitler's Germany, Mussolini's Italy and Stalin's Russia. These systems tried to control not only politics but also the whole life of the people, including schools, work, leisure and thought. A good answer will explain both why dictators appeared and how Fascism and Nazism were alike and different.

## BACKGROUND

After the First World War many new democracies were created in Europe, often with no tradition of parliament. The peace treaties left bitterness, the Russian Revolution of 1917 spread fear of communism, and the Great Depression after 1929 caused unemployment and hunger. People turned to leaders who promised order, jobs and national pride. Italy was a victor in 1918 but felt cheated of the lands promised in the secret Treaty of London of 1915, which it called a mutilated victory. Strikes and unrest in 1919 and 1920 frightened property owners. Mussolini, a former socialist, formed the Fascist movement in 1919 and used squads of blackshirts against socialists. His success inspired Hitler, who had also learned from the failed Munich Putsch of 1923 that power must be won by legal means.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Why dictatorships spread.** Disappointment with the peace, economic crisis, fear of communism, weak and divided parliaments and the glory of war spirit. A simple way to remember is F E A R: Failure of democracy, Economic crisis, Anger at the treaties, Red scare.
2. **Similarities.** Both had one party and one leader, the Duce and the Fuhrer. Both banned other parties, controlled the press, used propaganda, youth movements and secret police, and hated communism and liberalism. Both wanted expansion.
3. **Aims and race.** Mussolini believed in the supremacy of the state and said everything is in the state, nothing outside it. Hitler put race first, taught Aryan superiority and hatred of Jews, and this led to the Holocaust.
4. **Power.** Mussolini shared power with the king and made peace with the Church in the Lateran Treaty of 1929. Hitler combined the offices of President and Chancellor in 1934 and took total power.
5. **Rise to power.** Mussolini won office by the threat of the March on Rome in 1922 and the king invited him. Hitler came through elections and a political bargain and then built dictatorship step by step.

**Examiner's angle.** Dictatorship spread because of crisis, fear and the failure of young democracies. Fascism loved the state while Nazism loved the race. **Key dates:** 1917 Russian Revolution, 1922 March on Rome, 1929 Lateran Treaty and Depression, 1933 Hitler, 1934 Fuhrer.

# 17. How the War of 1939 Became a World War and the Role of the USA (1914 to 1945)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**MEDIUM**

## INTRODUCTION

The Second World War began in Europe in September 1939 when Germany invaded Poland. By December 1941 it covered Europe, Africa, the Atlantic and the Pacific. Two events made it global, the German invasion of the Soviet Union and the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor. In both world wars the actions of the United States changed the result. A world war is one in which the main powers on several continents fight together. The Second World War had two origins, the war of Germany in Europe and the war of Japan in Asia, and these two joined in 1941. The role of the United States should also be shown over the whole period from 1914 to 1945, because it grew from a creditor nation into the strongest power in the world.

## BACKGROUND

Japan had been fighting China since 1937 and in September 1940 it joined Germany and Italy in the Tripartite Pact. The fall of France in 1940 opened the French and Dutch colonies in Asia to Japanese pressure. The United States stayed officially neutral but gave Britain growing help. The war in Europe and the war in Asia were still separate until 1941. Between 1931 and 1939 Japan, Italy and Germany had each attacked weaker states, and the League of Nations had done nothing. In 1936 Germany and Japan signed the Anti Comintern Pact and Italy joined it in 1937. The United States passed Neutrality Acts in the 1930s to stay out of foreign wars, but President Roosevelt came to believe that a Nazi victory would threaten America, and he gradually moved the country toward supporting Britain.

## KEY POINTS

1. **1939 to 1940.** Britain and France declared war after Poland was invaded. Germany and the USSR divided Poland under the Nazi Soviet Pact. In 1940 Germany conquered Denmark, Norway, the Low Countries and France. Italy joined in June.
2. **Barbarossa, June 1941.** Hitler broke the pact and invaded the USSR on 22 June 1941. The largest land war in history began and Britain gained a powerful ally.
3. **Pearl Harbor, December 1941.** After the United States froze Japanese assets and stopped oil sales, Japan attacked the American fleet at Pearl Harbor on 7 December. Germany and Italy declared war on the USA on 11 December.
4. **The USA in the First World War.** America stayed neutral at first but lent money to the Allies. German submarine warfare and the Zimmermann Telegram brought it into the war in April 1917. Fresh troops and supplies in 1918 helped defeat Germany.
5. **The USA between the wars.** The Senate rejected Versailles and the League in 1920. The Dawes Plan loans of 1924 helped Germany recover, and the Wall Street Crash of 1929 ended that recovery and helped Hitler.
6. **The USA in the Second World War.** Lend Lease from 1941 supplied Britain and the USSR. American factories made huge numbers of ships, planes and tanks. The USA fought in the Pacific, North Africa and Normandy and used atomic bombs on Japan in 1945.

**Examiner's angle.** America's strength decided the First World War and its absence in the 1920s and 1930s helped cause the Second. Remember the two turns of 1941: Barbarossa and Pearl Harbor. **Key dates:** 1917 USA enters, 1920 Senate refuses League, 1939 Poland, 1940 Tripartite Pact, June 1941 Barbarossa, December 1941 Pearl Harbor.

# 18. The League of Nations (1920 to 1946)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**MEDIUM**

## INTRODUCTION

The League of Nations was created in 1920 by the Treaty of Versailles on the idea of President Wilson. Its headquarters was in Geneva. Its aim was collective security, which means that all members would join together against an aggressor. It had real success in small disputes but failed against great powers. The League was the first great attempt to prevent war by a standing organisation of states. Its idea was that aggressors could be stopped by moral pressure, economic sanctions and in the last resort by force. Its history is usually studied in two parts, the hopeful 1920s and the failing 1930s, and a good answer will explain why its fortunes changed.

## BACKGROUND

After the horror of the First World War many people believed that war could be ended by an international organisation. Wilson put the League in the Covenant of the peace treaty. The Assembly included all members while the Council had permanent seats for Britain, France, Italy and Japan. There was also a Permanent Court of Justice and the International Labour Organisation. Wilson had made the League the centre of his plan for peace, yet his own Senate rejected it, led by Henry Cabot Lodge, who feared that the League would drag America into foreign wars. Britain and France, the two strongest members, were weakened by the war and disagreed about how strict the League should be. France wanted a strong League to protect it from Germany, while Britain preferred a mild one.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Successes.** The League settled the Aaland Islands dispute between Finland and Sweden in 1921, the division of Upper Silesia, and a quarrel between Greece and Bulgaria in 1925. It helped refugees, fought disease and improved labour conditions.
2. **Weak membership.** The USA never joined because the Senate refused. Germany joined only in 1926 and left in 1933. The USSR joined in 1934 and was expelled in 1939. Japan and Italy left in the 1930s.
3. **Structural weakness.** The League had no army of its own. It relied on members to impose sanctions. Decisions needed the agreement of all, which made action slow. Britain and France put their own interests first. A way to remember is N U M B: No USA, Unanimity, Missing army, Big powers selfish.
4. **Manchuria, 1931.** Japan invaded Manchuria. The Lytton Report blamed Japan, so Japan left the League. No action was taken.
5. **Abyssinia, 1935.** Italy attacked Abyssinia. Sanctions were weak and did not cover oil. Britain and France tried the secret Hoare Laval Plan to give Mussolini much of the country.
6. **The United Nations.** The UN of 1945 includes the USA and USSR and has a Security Council with a veto. It has avoided a world war and done good work in health and refugee care, but the veto often paralyses it, as with Syria and Ukraine.

**Examiner's angle.** The League failed because it lacked force, unity and the main powers. It survived as an idea and its lessons were used to create the United Nations. **Key dates:** 1920 League begins, 1926 Germany joins, 1931 Manchuria, 1935 Abyssinia, 1939 USSR expelled, 1945 United Nations.

# 19. Origins of the Cold War (1945 to 1991)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**HIGH**

## INTRODUCTION

The Cold War was a long struggle between the United States and the Soviet Union after 1945. It was called cold because the two superpowers never fought each other directly, but they competed everywhere through alliances, arms, spies and proxy wars. It divided Europe into east and west for nearly half a century. Historians describe three schools of thought on its origins. The traditional view blames Soviet expansion, the revisionist view blames American economic power and ambition, and the post revisionist view blames mutual fear and misunderstanding. For a CSS answer it is wise to follow the third view and show that both sides made mistakes.

## BACKGROUND

The two powers had fought together against Hitler but they held opposite ideas. The USA stood for capitalism and democracy and the USSR for communism. Each believed the other wanted to rule the world. The alliance of war hid deep distrust. At Yalta in February 1945 and Potsdam in July 1945 the allies quarrelled over Poland, Germany and reparations. The USSR had lost about twenty seven million people in the war and its western lands had been devastated. It wanted security and reparations. The United States, by contrast, had become the richest nation in the world and was the only one with the atomic bomb. When Roosevelt died in April 1945 the new President Truman took a tougher view of Stalin. The Red Army also occupied most of eastern Europe at the end of the war, which allowed Stalin to put friendly governments in place.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Misperceptions.** Stalin wanted a buffer zone of friendly states in eastern Europe because Russia had been invaded twice in thirty years. The West saw this as expansion. Churchill's Iron Curtain speech of 1946 painted Russia as an aggressor, while Moscow believed that America sought world power.
2. **The atomic bomb.** The USA used it in 1945 and held a monopoly. The USSR tested its own bomb in 1949.
3. **Containment.** The Truman Doctrine of March 1947 promised aid to Greece and Turkey. The Marshall Plan of June 1947 gave billions of dollars to rebuild Europe. Stalin rejected it for eastern Europe and created the Cominform.
4. **Germany.** The western zones were merged. After a new currency was introduced, Stalin blockaded Berlin in 1948 and the West supplied the city by air for almost a year. In 1949 Germany split into West and East.
5. **NATO and the Warsaw Pact.** NATO was formed in April 1949 for collective defence. The Warsaw Pact was formed in 1955 after West Germany joined NATO. The Pact was dominated by Moscow and was used to crush Hungary in 1956 and Czechoslovakia in 1968.
6. **The end.** Gorbachev's glasnost and perestroika led to the fall of the Berlin Wall in November 1989, German reunification in 1990 and the end of the USSR in December 1991.

**Examiner's angle.** On Ukraine 2022, the echoes of the Cold War are clear in sanctions, nuclear threats and NATO enlargement, but it is a hot war without a communist ideology. Remember I T M B N: Iron Curtain, Truman, Marshall, Berlin, NATO. **Key dates:** 1945 Yalta and Potsdam, 1946 Iron Curtain, 1947 Truman and Marshall, 1948 Berlin Blockade, 1949 NATO, 1955 Warsaw Pact, 1989 Wall falls, 1991 USSR ends.

# 20. European Integration (1950 to today)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**MEDIUM**

## INTRODUCTION

After the Second World War European leaders wanted to make another war impossible. They decided to bind the economies of old enemies together. This idea led from a small coal and steel community to the European Union of today. The key idea is that countries which share their coal, steel and trade become so tied together that war between them is not only wrong but practically impossible. This method of building unity step by step is called functionalism. The Union that exists today has its own parliament, court and currency, but it is still a union of independent states.

## BACKGROUND

Europe in 1945 was ruined, divided by the Cold War and afraid of the old quarrel between France and Germany. American aid under the Marshall Plan created the OEEC in 1948 and the Council of Europe was founded in 1949. Many leaders believed that economic cooperation was the surest way to peace. Western Europe in 1945 was short of food, fuel and money. The United States gave about thirteen billion dollars under the Marshall Plan between 1948 and 1952 and asked European states to plan their recovery together. At the same time the fear of the Soviet Union and the wish to bind a recovering West Germany into a peaceful framework pushed France to propose pooling resources. Jean Monnet, a French planner, drafted the idea that Schuman announced.

## KEY POINTS

1. **The ECSC, 1951.** The French Foreign Minister Robert Schuman and Jean Monnet proposed in 1950 that France and Germany pool coal and steel. The ECSC was formed in 1951 by France, West Germany, Italy, Belgium, the Netherlands and Luxembourg.
2. **Treaty of Rome, 1957.** The same Six created the European Economic Community and Euratom in 1958. The EEC aimed at a common market with free movement of goods, workers, services and capital.
3. **Achievements.** Internal tariffs were removed by 1968. The Common Agricultural Policy of 1962 secured food and farm incomes. The Maastricht Treaty of 1992 created the European Union, and the euro appeared in 2002. Most important, there has been no war among members for decades.
4. **Britain stayed out.** Britain thought of itself as a world power with an empire, the Commonwealth and a special relationship with the USA. It led the European Free Trade Association in 1960 and many Britons feared loss of sovereignty.
5. **Entry delayed.** Britain applied in 1961 but President de Gaulle vetoed in 1963 and 1967 because he thought Britain was too tied to America. After he left office in 1969, the Hague summit agreed to enlargement and Britain joined on 1 January 1973.
6. **Challenges.** The euro debt crisis from 2010, the migrant crisis of 2015, the British vote to leave in 2016 and Brexit in January 2020 show the limits of integration.

**Examiner's angle.** Integration has turned old rivals into partners and made Europe a great economic power. Brexit shows that it still has critics. **Key dates:** 1950 Schuman Plan, 1951 ECSC, 1957 Rome, 1963 and 1967 vetoes, 1973 UK joins, 1992 Maastricht, 2002 euro, 2020 Brexit.

# 21. Britain: Industrial Revolution Without Political Revolution (1760 to 1850)

Ryan Knowledge Nexus | Detailed Notes

**Likelihood in CSS 2027**
**MEDIUM**

## INTRODUCTION

The Industrial Revolution began in Britain around 1760 and by 1850 Britain was the workshop of the world. France meanwhile went through political revolution but slower industry. Britain's change was an evolution and not a revolution in politics. The reasons lie in its economy and its political system. The question asks for two things, why industry grew and why politics stayed calm. A good answer has a first half on the economy and a second half on the political system, and it should link the two. The contrast with France, where revolution came first and industry later, helps to make the answer sharp.

## BACKGROUND

Britain had coal and iron close together, rivers and canals for transport, a strong navy, colonies for raw materials and markets, a good banking system and a growing population. An agricultural revolution freed labour and capital for industry. A government that respected property and trade gave businessmen confidence to invest. Britain was also lucky in its position as an island. It had no land frontier to defend, so it could spend less on armies than continental states and more on trade and the navy. Its overseas empire, especially India and the West Indies, provided cotton, sugar and markets. By 1851 the Great Exhibition in London displayed the nation's industrial success, and about half of its people lived in towns.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Key inventions.** Kay's flying shuttle, Hargreaves' spinning jenny in 1764, Arkwright's water frame in 1769, Crompton's mule, Cartwright's power loom, Watt's steam engine and Stephenson's railway in 1830 changed production and transport.
2. **A flexible political system.** The Glorious Revolution of 1688 had already limited the king and made Parliament supreme. The aristocracy accepted business and there was no hard wall between nobles and the middle class, as in France before 1789.
3. **Reform in time.** The Reform Act of 1832 gave the vote to the middle class. The Factory Act of 1833 and the Poor Law of 1834 dealt with some social problems. Trade unions became legal in 1824 and the Corn Laws were repealed in 1846.
4. **Control and repression.** When protest rose the state used force. The Peterloo Massacre and the Six Acts came in 1819. The Combination Acts of 1799 and 1800 limited workers' organisations, and the Luddites were punished severely.
5. **Fear of the French example.** The Terror of 1793 and the long wars with France made the elite cautious and many middle class people afraid of radical change.
6. **Safety valves.** Chartism from 1838 to 1848 asked for democratic reforms but was peaceful and divided. Methodism taught patience. Emigration and empire gave outlets, and by mid century real wages began to rise.

**Examiner's angle.** Britain avoided revolution because it had a flexible elite, reformed just in time and used force when needed. Remember F I R E: Flexible elite, Improvement by reform, Repression, Escape valves. **Key dates:** 1688 Glorious Revolution, 1764 spinning jenny, 1819 Peterloo, 1832 Reform Act, 1846 Corn Laws repealed, 1848 Chartism ends.

# 22. Stalinism (1924 to 1953)

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## INTRODUCTION

Stalinism means the rule of Joseph Stalin over the Soviet Union from the middle of the 1920s until his death in 1953. He turned a backward country into an industrial and military power, but he did it by terror and at the cost of millions of lives. His rule shaped both the Second World War and the Cold War. Historians disagree about whether Stalinism was the natural result of Leninism or a break from it. Some say that Lenin's one party state and use of terror led straight to Stalin. Others say Stalin added a new level of personal dictatorship and violence. The question is often set in comparison with Nazism, so it helps to know the similarities and differences.

## BACKGROUND

Lenin died in January 1924 without a clear successor. Stalin, as General Secretary of the party, defeated rivals such as Trotsky, Zinoviev and Bukharin and became sole leader by the end of the decade. He believed that Russia had to catch up with the West within ten years or be destroyed, and he proposed socialism in one country. After the civil war and the New Economic Policy the USSR was poor and mostly rural. Stalin argued against Trotsky that the country must build socialism alone and not wait for world revolution. He used his post as General Secretary to place his supporters in key jobs and gradually forced his rivals out of the party. By 1929 he was the unquestioned leader and was ready to begin what he called the revolution from above. The system that Stalin built is also called a command economy, because the state decided what to produce, how much and at what price. It also had a strong personal cult around Stalin, who was called the leader of the people and the great teacher. Posters, films and school books presented him as a wise father, while people who criticised him risked arrest.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Five Year Plans.** From 1928 the state set targets for heavy industry such as coal, steel and electricity. Giant new works and cities were built at great speed, with harsh discipline for workers.
2. **Collectivisation.** From 1929 peasants were forced into collective farms and the richer peasants, called kulaks, were destroyed. The result was the great famine of 1932 and 1933 that killed millions, including in Ukraine.
3. **The Great Purges.** Between 1936 and 1938 show trials and secret police removed old Bolsheviks, army leaders and many ordinary people. Millions were sent to the Gulag labour camps.
4. **Foreign policy.** Stalin signed the Nazi Soviet Pact in 1939. After Hitler's invasion in 1941 the USSR fought the Great Patriotic War and won, and then created a bloc of satellite states in eastern Europe.
5. **Assessment.** The USSR became an industrial power and defeated Germany. But the cost was terror, famine and the destruction of political freedom. Many historians judge the cost as far too high.

**Examiner's angle.** Stalin made the USSR strong but a tragedy for its people. Remember P F P: Plans, collectivised Farms, Purges. **Key dates:** 1924 Lenin dies, 1928 First Five Year Plan, 1929 collectivisation, 1932 to 1933 famine, 1936 to 1938 purges, 1939 Pact, 1945 victory.

# 23. Napoleon III and the Second Empire (1848 to 1870)

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## INTRODUCTION

Louis Napoleon, nephew of the great Napoleon, was elected President of France in 1848, made himself Emperor as Napoleon III in 1852 and ruled until his defeat at Sedan in 1870. He gave France economic growth and sought glory abroad to win support at home, but his foreign mistakes helped to destroy him. He is an important figure because his foreign policy touched both Italian and German unification. He wished to overturn the Vienna settlement of 1815, which France disliked, but he did not have the strength or the clear plan to do it. His career shows how a ruler who wants glory without a strong base can be defeated by cleverer rivals like Bismarck.

## BACKGROUND

The Second Republic of 1848 was weak and divided and many French people longed for order. The name of Napoleon was a powerful memory of national glory. Louis Napoleon won the presidential election of December 1848 with a large majority. When the constitution did not allow him a second term, he took power by a coup in December 1851. Louis Napoleon was born in 1808, grew up in exile and twice tried to seize power by failed coups in 1836 and 1840. After the Revolution of 1848 he returned and used his famous name and promises of order to win the votes of peasants and property owners. He wrote a pamphlet on the extinction of poverty and presented himself as a man who cared for workers as well as order. In his first years he governed through a strong police and a very limited parliament, which allowed him to avoid opposition. Many French people accepted this because they wanted peace after the unrest of 1848. His economic policy was friendly to business and to the new banks, such as the Credit Mobilier. He also signed a free trade treaty with Britain in 1860, called the Cobden Chevalier Treaty, which opened French markets to British goods and angered some French manufacturers.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Rise to power.** President in 1848, coup in December 1851 and Emperor in December 1852 after a plebiscite. At first he ruled as an authoritarian with a strict press and a weak parliament.
2. **Domestic policy.** Railways, banks and industry grew. Baron Haussmann rebuilt Paris with wide boulevards. After 1860 he made the empire more liberal and gave the parliament more voice.
3. **Crimean War.** Napoleon joined Britain against Russia in 1854. France gained prestige and Paris hosted the peace congress of 1856.
4. **Italy.** He agreed with Cavour at Plombieres in 1858 and fought Austria in 1859. He gained Nice and Savoy but made a sudden peace at Villafranca and lost the confidence of both Italians and French Catholics.
5. **Failures.** His Mexican adventure from 1861 to 1867 ended in disaster. He allowed Bismarck to defeat Austria in 1866 and gained nothing. In 1870 he was drawn into war with Prussia, was captured at Sedan and died in exile in England.

**Examiner's angle.** Napoleon III sought glory abroad to hide weakness at home. His mistakes helped Italian and German unity, and Sedan ended his rule. **Key dates:** 1848 President, 1851 coup, 1852 Emperor, 1856 Paris Congress, 1858 Plombieres, 1867 Mexico ends, 1870 Sedan.

# 24. Imperialism and the Scramble for Africa (1870 to 1914)

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## INTRODUCTION

The new imperialism of the late nineteenth century saw European powers seize most of Africa and large parts of Asia in just a few decades. It was driven by economic need, national pride and a belief in a civilising mission. The scramble for Africa created rivalries that helped to bring about the First World War. This topic is useful because it links economic history with diplomacy. By 1914 about ninety percent of Africa was under European rule, with only Ethiopia and Liberia independent. The effects were large for both sides, and a good answer should include the African viewpoint as well as the European one.

## BACKGROUND

Until 1870 Europeans held only coastal trading posts in most of Africa. After 1870 industry demanded raw materials and new markets, and strong states wished to win prestige by colonies. Better weapons, steamships and medicine such as quinine made exploration of the interior possible. Explorers like Stanley and the ambitions of King Leopold II of Belgium opened the Congo. Before the scramble, European attention had been on trade rather than rule. Britain banned the slave trade in 1807 and missionaries and explorers such as David Livingstone opened the interior to Europeans. Newspapers made the public eager for empire, and politicians believed that colonies gave power and markets in an age when other nations were raising tariff walls. Leopold II's Congo scheme in the 1870s and 1880s alarmed other powers and set off the race. Technology made conquest easier. The Maxim machine gun, first used in the 1880s, gave Europeans a great advantage over African armies. In 1898 at Omdurman in Sudan a small British force with machine guns and rifles defeated a much larger army, which showed the gap in military power.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Causes.** The causes can be remembered as three Gs: Gold for economic gain, Glory for national prestige, God for the so called civilising mission. Strategic needs such as naval bases also mattered.
2. **Berlin Conference, 1884 and 1885.** The powers met to set rules for the division of Africa. Effective occupation became the test of a claim. The Congo was placed under Leopold II. No African ruler was invited.
3. **Britain.** Britain occupied Egypt in 1882, and took large parts of East, West and Southern Africa.
4. **France and Germany.** France took much of West and North Africa. Germany took Togo, Cameroon, South West Africa and East Africa.
5. **Rivalry.** The Fashoda crisis of 1898 almost brought Britain and France to war. The Moroccan crises of 1905 and 1911 raised tension between Germany and France.
6. **Impact.** Straight line borders divided peoples and caused lasting problems. Resistance and later independence struggles followed, and imperial rivalry added to the road to 1914.

**Examiner's angle.** Imperialism brought wealth to Europe and suffering to Africa, and it raised tension between the powers. **Key dates:** 1870 industrial demand grows, 1882 Egypt, 1884 and 1885 Berlin Conference, 1898 Fashoda, 1905 and 1911 Morocco.

# 25. The Weimar Republic (1919 to 1933)

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## INTRODUCTION

The Weimar Republic was the democratic government of Germany between 1919 and 1933. It was born in defeat, survived a series of crises, enjoyed a few calm years and then collapsed under the Great Depression. Its failure opened the way for Hitler. Historians ask whether Weimar was doomed from the start or whether it could have survived. The Republic had real achievements in the arts, science and social welfare, and it survived early attacks. Its end came from the Depression combined with long term weaknesses, so a good answer should avoid blaming only the economy.

## BACKGROUND

In November 1918 Germany lost the war, the Kaiser fled and a republic was declared. A new constitution was written in the city of Weimar. The Republic signed the Treaty of Versailles, which many Germans hated, and was blamed for defeat in the stab in the back myth. It had to rule a divided country that had little experience of democracy. The constitution of 1919 was very democratic. It gave votes to women, set up a President elected by the people and a Reichstag chosen by proportional representation. But the old elites, such as army officers, judges and big landowners, kept their influence. Many ordinary Germans did not believe the Republic was theirs, and the extreme parties on the left, the Communists, and on the right, the Nazis, wanted to destroy it. Weimar also faced a problem of image. Its leaders had signed the armistice and the peace treaty, so right wing critics called them the November criminals who had betrayed the army. Political violence was common in the early years, and leading figures such as Walther Rathenau, the Foreign Minister, were murdered in 1922. The Republic never gained the loyalty that a new state needs in its first years.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Early troubles.** Left and right risings broke out. The Kapp Putsch of 1920 tried to overthrow the Republic. Political murders were common.
2. **The crisis of 1923.** France and Belgium occupied the Ruhr when Germany failed to pay reparations. Hyperinflation destroyed savings and ruined the middle class. Hitler tried the Munich Putsch.
3. **The golden years, 1924 to 1929.** Gustav Stresemann restored stability with a new currency, the Dawes Plan of 1924 and the Locarno Treaties of 1925. Germany joined the League in 1926 and enjoyed growth and a flowering of culture.
4. **Weaknesses.** Proportional representation produced many small parties. Article 48 allowed the President to rule by decree. The army, judges and civil servants were often hostile to democracy.
5. **Collapse.** The Wall Street Crash of 1929 ended American loans and brought unemployment of six million. Chancellors ruled by decree. The Nazi vote rose and Hitler became Chancellor in January 1933.

**Examiner's angle.** Weimar was a house built in a storm. Remember the four Bs: Born in defeat 1919, Burned in 1923, Better 1924 to 1929, Broken 1929 to 1933. **Key dates:** 1919 Republic, 1920 Kapp Putsch, 1923 Ruhr and hyperinflation, 1924 Dawes Plan, 1925 Locarno, 1929 Crash, 1933 Hitler.

# 26. Alexander II and Reform in Russia (1855 to 1881)

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**MEDIUM**

## INTRODUCTION

Alexander II was Tsar of Russia from 1855 to 1881. He is called the Tsar Liberator because he freed the serfs in 1861 and carried out the Great Reforms. The reforms were limited and did not satisfy radicals, and in 1881 he was killed by a bomb. His reign is often seen as the great age of reform before 1917. It matters because it shows how a ruler may begin reform and then lose control of the forces it releases. Historians still debate whether the reforms were enough to save the Tsarist system or whether they only made the people hope for more.

## BACKGROUND

Nicholas I, who ruled from 1825 to 1855, governed by autocracy, censorship and the secret police known as the Third Section. Russia fell behind the West in industry and in the army. Defeat in the Crimean War in 1856 showed the Tsar's weakness. Alexander II decided that reform from above was safer than revolution from below. Alexander II was born in 1818 and came to the throne in the middle of the Crimean War. The war showed that serf armies could not match the railways, rifles and steamships of Britain and France. He said in 1856 that it was better to abolish serfdom from above than to wait for it to be abolished from below. Landowners resisted, so the reform was prepared slowly by committees and became a compromise. Alexander also faced growing demands from educated Russians. Writers, students and officers had read Western books and wanted a constitution, free speech and a fair legal system. The Polish revolt of 1863 against Russian rule alarmed him and made him less willing to loosen control. At the same time new railways and the growth of towns began to change Russian society, so the reforms had to deal with a country that was changing quickly. These pressures show why his reforms were both a response to weakness and a gamble to keep the monarchy strong.

## KEY POINTS

1. **Emancipation of the serfs, 1861.** About twenty million serfs received personal freedom. They received land but had to pay redemption money for many years and remained poor and bound to the village commune.
2. **Local government, 1864.** Councils called zemstvos were created in the districts and provinces to manage schools, roads and health. Nobles still dominated them.
3. **Legal reform, 1864.** Courts were made independent with public trials and juries. This was a great step toward the rule of law.
4. **Army reform, 1874.** Military service was extended to all classes and the term of service was shortened.
5. **Limits and reaction.** The Tsar refused any national parliament. Radicals such as the Nihilists and Narodniks wanted more and some turned to terror. Alexander II was assassinated in 1881. His son Alexander III turned to reaction.

**Examiner's angle.** Reforms came after defeat and were too small for radicals and too big for conservatives. Remember S Z L A: Serfs, Zemstvos, Law, Army. **Key dates:** 1855 Alexander II, 1856 Crimean defeat, 1861 serfs freed, 1864 zemstvos and courts, 1874 army reform, 1881 assassination.

# 27. The Balkan Wars (1912 to 1913)

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**MEDIUM**

## INTRODUCTION

The two Balkan Wars of 1912 and 1913 were fought over the last Ottoman lands in Europe. In the first war the Balkan states defeated the Ottomans. In the second they quarrelled over the spoils. The result was a stronger Serbia, a frightened Austria and a Europe closer to the war of 1914. These wars are important because they are often overlooked yet lead directly to 1914. Both wars changed the balance of power in the Balkans and pulled the great powers into a diplomatic crisis. They also showed the danger of nationalism when several small states claim the same land.

## BACKGROUND

The Young Turk revolution of 1908 weakened the Ottoman government. Austria annexed Bosnia in 1908, Italy attacked Libya in 1911 and the empire looked weak. Russia encouraged the Balkan states to unite. Serbia, Bulgaria, Greece and Montenegro formed the Balkan League in 1912 to win freedom for their peoples in Macedonia and Thrace. Macedonia was claimed by Serbia, Bulgaria and Greece, and its mixed population made any division difficult. In 1912 secret treaties were signed between the Balkan states, with Russian help, which prepared the League. The Ottoman Empire was also fighting Italy over Libya, which left it weak. When the war began in October 1912 the Ottoman army was beaten in a matter of weeks, and Bulgarian forces came close to Constantinople. The Great Powers watched anxiously. Russia supported the Balkan states as fellow Slavs, but it did not want a general war and urged caution. Austria wanted to stop Serbia from reaching the Adriatic Sea and was alarmed that its own Slav subjects might look to Serbia for leadership. Germany promised support to Austria. Britain and Germany worked together at the London conference of 1912 and 1913, which created Albania, and this showed that war could still be avoided by talks. But the tension between Austria and Serbia was not solved, and many leaders already felt that another Balkan crisis would lead to a larger war.

## KEY POINTS

1. **First Balkan War, 1912.** The Balkan League attacked the Ottomans in October 1912 and won quickly. Ottoman power in Europe was almost destroyed.
2. **Treaty of London, 1913.** The Ottomans gave up almost all their European land. The Great Powers also created the new state of Albania, partly to keep Serbia from the sea.
3. **Second Balkan War, 1913.** Bulgaria was unhappy with its share and attacked Serbia and Greece in June 1913. Romania and the Ottomans joined against Bulgaria and Bulgaria was quickly defeated.
4. **Treaty of Bucharest, 1913.** Bulgaria lost much of what it had won. Serbia and Greece gained territory and Romania received part of Bulgaria.
5. **Results.** Serbia nearly doubled in size and dreamed of uniting all southern Slavs. Austria saw this as a mortal danger to its empire. Russia supported Serbia. Germany tied itself closer to Austria.

**Examiner's angle.** The Balkan Wars were the last phase of the Eastern Question before 1914. They made Serbia strong and Austria afraid, and Sarajevo followed in a year. **Key dates:** 1908 Bosnia annexed, 1911 Libya, October 1912 first war, May 1913 Treaty of London, June 1913 second war, August 1913 Bucharest.

# A Note Before You Study

These detailed notes give the introduction, the background and the key points for each topic. Use them together with the Model Answers PDF for full answers and with the Memory Guide for pictures and memory tricks. Please check dates and facts against your recommended textbooks such as Southgate's Text Book of European History and Stuart Miller's Mastering Modern European History. Prepared for CSS aspirants by **Ryan Knowledge Nexus**.